

After twenty years of studying millionaires across a wide spectrum of industries, we have concluded that the character of the business owner is more important in predicting his level of wealth than the classification of his business.

But no matter how hard we try to make our point, reporters want to keep things simple. What a great story, what a great headline, it would make if they could tell readers:

Here are ten businesses millionaires own!

We have gone out of our way to emphasize that there are no sure steps one can take to become wealthy. Too often reporters ignore the facts. They sensationalize and twist our research findings. Yes, you are more likely to become affluent if you're self-employed. But what some of these reporters don't tell you is that most business owners are not millionaires and will never come close to becoming wealthy.

We do tell reporters that some industries tend to be more profitable than others. Thus, those who own businesses in the more profitable industries tend, by definition, to realize more income. But just because you're in a profitable industry does not guarantee that your business will be highly productive. And even if your business is highly productive, you may never become wealthy. Why? Because even if you earn big profits, you may spend even bigger amounts on nonbusiness-related consumer goods and services. You may have been divorced three times or have a habit of gambling on the horses. You may not have a pension plan or own any shares in quality, publicly traded corporations. Perhaps you feel little need to accumulate wealth. Money, in your mind, may be the most easily renewable resource. If you think it is, you may be a spender and never an investor.

But what if you're frugal and a conscientious investor and you own a business that is profitable? In this case, you're likely to become wealthy.

It is easier to earn higher profits in some industries than others. We identify several of these profitable industries in this chapter. But again, we caution readers not to oversimplify our findings and suggestions. Too often people want a "sound-bite" answer to the question of how to become wealthy in America. Even worse are those who distort our data-based findings. Consider, along these lines, the message that was recently left for us by a business broker: